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Alfred (A.B.) Spellman

A.B. Spellman has led a distinguished career as a poet, essayist, arts advocate, and jazz enthusiast. His works include The Beautiful Days, Four Lives in the Bebop Business, *and* Things I Must Have Known, *for which he received the NAACP Image Award for Outstanding Literary Work and Poetry.*

A.B. was interviewed via Zoom on January 19, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have A.B. Spellman with me today, who is a poet, an essayist, a jazz writer, arts advocate, teacher, and a man who hitchhiked from D.C. to New York to hear Cecil Taylor play the piano. That takes some commitment.

AS: Not when you're twenty years old. When you're twenty years old all these things are easy. "Let's go to New York, let's hitchhike." You know?

MR: Yeah. What was it about his music that caused you to do that?

AS: Well power I think, that was the thing about the new music, the late 50s and 1960s was that there was so much power in it. And your mind was never at rest when you were hearing it. Your mind was always open and moving, and always challenged. And I couldn't get enough of it. I couldn't find it in any other aspect of life.

MR: Was there a set-up for you musically specifically with jazz artists? And when I say set-up I'll share a brief little anecdote of myself that the first John Coltrane record I bought unknowingly was "Om." And that was not a set-up.

AS: Well you thought about going heaven, didn't you.

MR: Yes. And it scared me off a little bit, but I wonder, what set you up to enjoy Cecil Taylor?

AS: Cecil Taylor? Well first of all, when I first got into Cecil Taylor he was not quite the powerhouse he was at the time that he was a few years later. He was still finding his voice and he was playing in little coffee houses around Greenwich Village and on some pretty raggedy pianos, and I got to watch him in the late 50s, I got to watch him grow, which is always a wonderful thing to do with another artist, to watch them grow, watch them actually empower themselves. And so by the early 60s you could see the power that I spoke of earlier was there. It was music that I had never heard before, it was music that didn't exist anywhere else. He was not like anybody else, which is also a very rare thing to find, an artist who is not like another artist. Cecil wasn't. So I just became thoroughly, thoroughly involved with what he was doing, and also I was getting to know him a little bit and that too is a great situation to have, to know an artist who is in the process of growing.

MR: Did you feel that his personality was reflected in his music that seemed to always be seeking the far boundaries? I may not be speaking exactly on point here but did he have a personality that reflected the way he played?

AS: He had a conversation that reflected the way he played. His personality was that of one that you would recognize, a very, very, very smart person who had a mind that was flying all over the place as he talked, who was extremely curious about all manner of things and had strong opinions about all manner of things. He used to borrow my records of contemporary composers, Cage and Morton Feldman and others, Stockhausen — he would borrow those until I stopped lending them to him because he'd always give them back all scratched up. And he got very angry about that, I don't think he ever forgave me for that. So he was always, always exploring and always curious. But he was also very, very serious and made certain that he studied the roots as much as he studied the expanse of music.

MR: Did you hear him with various sidemen and if so did you observe anything watching the sidemen that reflected the challenge of playing with Cecil Taylor?

AS: Yeah, not everybody could do it, and not just sideman also like co-partners. I mean you know if you listen to the Mary Lou Williams/Cecil Taylor record they're not always in accord. Or the Max Roach one, where they — certainly they had no trouble finding a common rhythm but the question of whose voice would be on top was an issue. But there is great music on both of those recordings. There are points at which they'd come together brilliantly. But as for the sidemen he basically developed musicians. Sonny Murray for example, who actually is a more important drummer than is generally acknowledged. Sonny I saw grow through his work with Cecil, you could see it, see his improvement. And his sense of finding out what Cecil needed from the drums, which was not propulsion as Cecil certainly had enough of that, but more of a pattern of, what am I looking for — a more of an impulse that could just sort of work in concert with the piano. So you could see Jimmy Lyons for example, a very, very good musician who should be noted more. Jimmy Lyons was able to play a more standard kind of a sound but would have the rhythmic capability as well as the fluidity not to get stuck from bar line to bar line but to just flow across it all and go wherever Cecil took him, still at the same time remaining very accessible. So yes, he basically developed people.

MR: You sound like you were or are a musician.

AS: No.

MR: Were you ever — did you ever aspire to be one?

AS: I studied voice as an elective in college. I had a very good voice but no talent for singing. Nobody ever got mad at me for singing but nobody — I didn't get notes from the ladies at the bar asking me to come over for a drink either. So nobody ever gave me big

applause but there was always polite applause and that is a fact, but no, I got into poetry by the time I left college and that's what I decided to pursue.

MR: What part did your love of jazz play in the construction of your poems?

AS: It's a difficult question to answer straight on. The thing is that they are entirely different things. Jazz, as stimulus, jazz has a way of keeping that part of the mind that hooks up the, hooks up reason and intuition which basically is what poetry is. They could work that way as jazz as an accompanist. But on the other hand I can't write to jazz you know. I cannot. I cannot write a word to jazz. I can write to classical music you know but I cannot write to jazz. Charlie Parker, John Coltrane, I can't write a word.

MR: I just noticed that struck me, because I was reading "Dear John Coltrane" your poem, and it says, "In the dead of night I'm writing poetry in another hotel room and J.S. Bach is on the radio." And I went back and read that again, because the title, "John Coltrane," and you're listening to J.S. Bach. It was a nice juxtaposition.

AS: Yeah, yeah. I mean it's all music. It's all music. It wouldn't surprise me if Bach were alive today that he'd be a jazz musician. He was a great improviser after all and I think probably that may be how he did most of his compositions. For a man to write that many cantatas can't possibly have been sitting there putting it all down. I think he improvised a lot of music and had people copied it for him as he played. That was a guess I got from a composer of my acquaintance. But at any rate, yeah, I think that there is again that kind of note to note discovery that you hear in the great musicians, you know where you know that they are finding something every time they write or play a phrase. That is an element of the music that I think is what makes it, which distinguishes the quality of musicians. There is always something new to them and to us in everything they write.

MR: Do you feel that that might be one reason why jazz requires more of listeners than most pop music?

AS: Well yes. First of all jazz does require, it has always demanded that you be in the music. Some of that has to do with dance roots and it's unfortunate I think that jazz lost its dance roots as most of the great — as many of the great musics have done. I mean like Latin music, it retained its Latin jazz dance base but you lose a lot when you remove that dance element from it. You lose, first of all, a basic way of communicating with the audience because it's one thing to have the music get you up out of your seat and move you, and another to have you sitting there and concentrating, which is not — which is beyond the capacity of a lot of people. A lot of people really can't sit and be quiet and listen to music and do nothing else, just concentrate and listen for an hour or two without saying a word. So I think that — but the thing is if you can do that, you can do that, great music can do so much more for you. You know it can do a lot for you. It can inspire, it can confirm, it

can actually give direction, it can take you places you haven't been. And so yeah, I think that the question was originally about poetry was it not?

MR: It was. We did an improvisation.

AS: Okay I'm trying to be like Art Tatum here, and get way, way, way off the harmonic structure of the song and find these elaborate ways to get back to it. I'm trying to do that but I am not Art Tatum. But anyway to poetry, poetry is almost antithetical to jazz in a way, especially if you write contemplative poetry as I do. I am not a performance poet. And I think the poems read well because they are basically conversational, but I don't write for performances, a lot of contemporary poets do. There's a generational difference. But at any rate, poetry does require of you complete attention, quietness, and a kind of subjective study, a study of the word that does not necessarily involve your reason or necessarily involve specific application to the rest of the world. It involves a different kind of application to the world. It requires a certain kind of insight that you can apply but it is not giving you specific insight in that sense of William Carlos Williams' famous poem about how poetry — how you cannot learn the news from reading a poem but yet men die every day from lack of it. So yes, I think that poetry, and it's basic what we used to call mind expansion back in the day, that poetry and music both offer. Poetry and serious music both offer. Your mind can expand and it can find places to settle that it would not be able to settle if you were not led there by an artist.

MR: I love the way you combine adjectives and nouns which — I'll give you an example, at the end of "Dear John Coltrane" and you said, "If you, J.C. and Bach ever swap infinite fours" I just think that's marvelous, like "infinite fours." And it also begs the question how did you learn about the terminology that jazz musicians use all the time? The trading of fours, and the exchanges and back and forth? Was that by observing or did someone sort of take you under their wing and talk to you about that?

AS: Well in New York I knew a lot of jazz musicians and I knew them very well. I mean that was a part of our world. The thing about the lower Manhattan arts scene in the 1960s was about as close as America ever got to say Montmartre at the turn of the 19th and 20th century, the modernism there. A great concentration of artists of all disciplines living in a relatively small area. They all knew each other, they all hung out together, they went to each other's parties, they drank together, and the exchange was wonderful. And lower Manhattan at that time you could drop in on people like Ornette Coleman or Alan Ginsburg or Larry Rivers, sit down and have a drink and watch them work and they'd talk to you. And I went by Ornette's once and I remember he said, "A.B. I've got this new tune, I think it's going to be really good. I've got some problems to work out over here in this part of it, but I think once I get that set up it's going to be really good and let me play for you what I've got so far." And it turned out to be "Lonely Woman" which I

think was one of Ornette's greatest, greatest tunes. You'd go by, I was roommates with a painter named Bob Thompson who is getting some attention right now, and Bob, he's been dead for several years. And he'd be there working and he'd be there working and have his music on. That's one, painters could listen to jazz and work. I always envied that. They'd have it up really, really loud and he'd be practically dancing into his canvas and he'd be talking about it. And it's the same with all the musicians, I mean you'd be playing basketball at a pick-up basketball game at Tompkins Square Park and you'd be playing with poets and painters and actors, you know, and it's just a pick-up game but it's also exchange. You see what I'm saying? Then of course there are the bars which we all went to more than we should have. So yeah, so I knew a lot of jazz musicians, and once I started writing about it they would seek me out and they'd have new records and "Can you write my liner notes for me" you know. "Can you put me on your radio" — I had a radio show on WBAI for a while. "Can you play this record on the radio show?" So I got to know them, and I would go to their recording sessions sometimes and so you know I got to look into the music quite a bit and got to hear them speak. And so yeah, I learned all this stuff from them. They taught me how to write about music, or how to write about them basically.

MR: Did you ever have an occasion where you wrote about a musician and made some opinions of your own, perhaps some assumptions, and then heard from that musician saying, "I was not thinking that" or "that was not my intention?"

AS: It happened with liner notes all the time because I always showed them the notes before I turned them in.

MR: I see.

AS: And they'd make corrections on them, yes. Yeah I think this thing about, incidentally the thing I want to diverge from your question a bit but it's related, this thing about artists, about poets learning to write about art forms from the artists themselves. I mean it's a similar kind of thing that came up and again, going back to, I thought of this when I started talking about Montmartre. If you look at the early Impressionists, it wasn't the academic critics who wrote about Manet for example. Baudelaire was Manet's critic and if you look at the Impressionists it was always the poets who wrote the reviews not because the Academy was adamantly opposed to this it was Apollinaire who wrote about Matisse. And they were great friends. They went out and they chased women together, they got drunk together, but basically Matisse taught Apollinaire how to write about his art. So I think that is what happened with LeRoi Jones, Amiri Baraka and me. We were hanging out with the musicians and they basically taught us how to write about them, not formally but you know we learned in conversation and listening to them and watching them work.

MR: Well you can't pay for that kind of education.

AS: No indeed.

MR: Yeah. There were some phrases, when you wrote about, this is from your first edition intro of your *Four Lives in Bebop* book and you were talking about the new jazz in the 60s and that the musicians broke down tonal centers and chord progressions and pat rhythms, any structure they found inhibiting. And I wonder if in so doing did the musicians expect that the audience was going to stay with them?

AS: I think they wondered about that. They were concerned about it but at this time you've got to bear in mind the time that this was. This was a time of challenge, of breaking institutions, of changing society, and it was expected of a committed artist or a committed activist that one would have to change the people to whom their work was pointed. You had the same thing with Malcolm X, always trying to change minds. Martin King was trying to change the attitude of African-American people as well as the white people who he was challenging about segregation and Jim Crow. So that was an assumption that permeated the work of artists as well. You were trying to change your medium first of all, and you were trying to change the people who would receive the medium. It was John Coltrane's great commitment to change people with his music and that's how the music got so hard for many people to hear. It was always easy for me because, again, I had lived through all of his progressions, but for people who had not had that experience it was often a hard music to hear. But his sense was if you will sit here and submit to what I am playing you will be different and a better person. He was asked what was he trying to accomplish with his music and he said, "I want to make people saints." And he was serious about that.

MR: This morning I was reading that comment that I just read to you about breaking down tonal centers and I got this little flash I said, I remember reading something about a liner note that said something about be advised that this record cannot be loved or understood in one sitting. So I went and got my "Ascension" LP and there you were. And you said that this is a "guaranteed soul rinsing." So I find it interesting what you just said about John Coltrane and trying to make people saints.

AS: Yeah you have to submit to art sometimes, you know what I mean? You have to give up all your expectation and basically even your sense of self and submit to the work itself in order to receive it fully. It's an experience on both ends that is not entirely rational but largely intuitional. And so it takes a certain kind of discipline to be able to do that. But people who don't listen to music all the time seriously, then it can be hard to have that experience and to have the music work for you in a way that the musicians intended. But if you can do that, if you can give yourself up to it and just sort of fly with them, they'll take you somewhere.

MR: I'm trying to think of an example, we were talking about breaking down structures. I'm trying to think of an example of some progressive jazz where they broke down the harmonies and melodically but the dance oriented groove remained. Because it seems like as people broke down these parts of what we think of as music that they all were breaking down at the same time and what we got from that was sometimes free jazz. I'm not sure if I'm verbalizing my question but can you think of any musicians who sort of kept a dance feel to their music yet became very explorative with the other parts of it?

AS: Well yeah, they — well yes certainly. Like go back to bebop, Dizzy Gillespie was very, very interested in solving the relationship between the dance times of Latin music and the dance times of jazz. And the one is not in the same place, which was difficult at first for the musicians trying to cross that line. If you listen to the early recordings of the Gillespie orchestra with Chano Pozo you will see that they're not always in the same place certainly at the very beginning. And later on as it got to "Tin Tin Deo" and some of the other tunes you see they do finally merge. Now on top of this dance rhythm there are all these flying bebop lines but certainly the synthesis of different rhythmic patterns from different cultures was a matter that required some serious study and work. And Chano Pozo actually was, he was an arrogant kind of dude anyway, but he thought he was the superior musician to these Gillespie orchestra people because he could play in 4/4 but they couldn't play in his rhythms. But again that worked out. I mean you follow some very good musicians who Mario Bauza had originally hired to be in the — oh man my brain is leaking — I have a serious brain leak today.

MR: I should be able to help you out so I'm having one also.

AS: At any rate some very great jazz musicians in their early experiences with Latin rhythm really had very great difficulty, you know, finding the one, finding the pulse. And it took a while to work it out. Gillespie sat in for a good year or two with Latin orchestras so he could be at ease with Latin rhythms. But yeah, I think that these dance rhythms, you have like a more of a universal human pulse to them that helps the music get over, and it makes it easier to listen to the melodic lines if you're tapping your foot to the rhythm.

MR: Are you a listener of current jazz recordings?

AS: I really haven't been keeping up lately as much as I should. I get most of the current material off the radio which means that I don't get to hear the current avante garde that often. When I do hear it it sounds like the old avante garde. It sounds 60 years old to me, which isn't very avante garde but, yeah, but I don't go out and buy all the new CDs anymore. I'm giving more attention to poetry now than I am to the music.

MR: Yeah it's a little stunning to think how many years ago it was that some of this incredible experimentation was going on in jazz.

AS: Well they tell me that there's great experimentation going on now but I don't really hear a lot of it. People like Vijay Iyer I think brought some newer stuff to it. It's always interesting how people can come from other cultures and bring those cultures into jazz. It's the great thing about jazz that it can settle almost anywhere and pick up on whatever the rhythms and harmonies and lines of that culture are and it can work in with the music. I remember just after apartheid fell and I was at the association — the artist's education association, jazz education association, IAJE — International Association of Jazz Education. And I was at the conference and there was this quartet of young South African musicians, students from South Africa playing. And at the piano was an Indian fellow who obviously had a great classical background. There was another young Indian fellow playing the tabla and then there was a Zulu kid playing the bass and there was a white kid playing the flute, a white girl playing the flute. And they made this music and it was just interesting that the point at which apartheid fell and all these cultures are now talking to each other in a way that they weren't talking before that jazz becomes the vocabulary that makes a lot of it possible. I thought that was a very interesting thing to see.

MR: I've often felt that America's greatest export has been its music. If you go around the world that jazz is in every continent and of course our rock & roll and hip hop now is pretty much heard everywhere.

AS: Yeah, that is true, that is true. But you know on the other hand we listen to them too. You know we listen, more people know about gamelan and ragas and African and griot music and such than ever before so yeah, it's an exchange.

MR: Well let's talk about your poetry for a bit. I wonder first of all do you decide, as a young man, to be a poet?

AS: I decided to be a poet when I was in college.

MR: And is that something, from a practical sense, that you felt you could make a living at?

AS: No. Not at all. I did not at all think about making a living. I just thought that I wanted to write. I didn't want — I left home, left Elizabeth City, North Carolina in 1952 to go to Howard University to study to be pre-med. The high school I went to in Elizabeth City was really very poor and extremely easy for me. I didn't even take my books home at night and I was valedictorian. So when I got to college there I was without a study habit to my name and I really bombed out in pre-med you know because I really did not have any sense about how to be a student and I was the kind of student who read everything but what he was assigned. I met LeRoi Jones Baraka when I went there. I mean it was kind of funny I remember the day I met him I had just arrived and I had this outfit that I had shopped all year for to go to Howard. And it was basically a Zoot suit but except it was a sport coat and pants and the shoulders were out to here, this huge lapel tapered all the way down to the crotch to a tight-fitting waist. The pants flared out 14 inches at the

thigh and nine inches at the cuff and it was a blue and white herringbone jacket against a powder blue pair of pants with one dark blue stitch going down the side which sort of pulled the outfit together, and a pair of alligator suede wingtips. And I knew I was sharp. And I got to campus and everybody's in Brooks Brothers. Or it might not have been Brooks Brothers, it might have been, I don't know, J. Crew or whatever cheaper versions of it are but I was immediately out of place. And that's what I was wearing when I met Baraka. And I had this hat — we got to be friends, I don't know why because he was a year ahead of me, I don't know why he took me in but he did. And I had this hat that I thought was wonderful. But he hated it. And one drunken night he snatched my hat and ran across campus and threw it in the reservoir. And so in other words you know you can't dress like this and hang out with me was the basic message. So at any rate, no so my college years are like everybody's college years, wonderful and a case of a way of finding myself and growing up. But it soon became apparent to me that I wanted to live a more creative life. I was always attracted to the creative offerings that the school had — the theater group, now I joined the theater company, the Howard Players I had a lead role in "He Who Gets Slapped." And there was a time that I was reading existentialism and I'm reading Sartre and Camus and Kierkegaard and dying to find people to use it on. I had this one line where the guy says "Who are you?" And my line was, "I am he who gets slapped." But I had decided for some weird Kierkegaardian reason that it wasn't "he who gets slapped" but it was "he who gets slapped." I had a very profound explanation for this. I remember Mr. Dawson, the director, said, "No, Spellman, that's not the line. You say, 'I am he who gets slapped.'" I said, "No but you realize that with issues of reunification and the self and I started going on. He said, "Look you're not a theater major, I have many theater majors who would like to have this part, you can say, 'I am he who gets slapped' or in about five minutes more these theater majors are going to have the part." So but anyway it was, you know, utterly pretentious college student. But even in the course of all that pretention you do learn and you do grow and you do think a lot about things. But by my junior year I was really fully committed to being a poet.

MR: The poetry, did it lead somehow to writing record reviews and, or were your record reviews a way to make some income?

AS: Yeah definitely. Let me see, Baraka got me into writing record reviews. He was doing it. And when I moved to New York he was my closest friend and he thought I could do it well and he introduced me to Dan Morgenstern who was the editor of not Down—*Metronome* magazine at the time, and Dan let me write some — I wrote introducing Archie Schepp article and he gave me some records to review, and so that's how I got started in it. I wasn't feeling all that qualified to do it to tell you the truth, but then when basically the jazz establishment, response to the new music convinced me that I ought to

do it because all these articles were coming out about anti-jazz and John Coltrane was considered to be anti-jazz as was Cecil and numerous others, Ornette and others. And so I would go to this concert, and I would go to this one at the Village Gate say, and I'd hear John Coltrane, he'd be wailing. And I'd leave there really feeling like I just had the soul rinsing that I had mentioned in those liner notes that you referred to, and just practically limp from the experience, and I'd open the magazine and see that John Coltrane was the worst thing that ever happened to jazz. You know. So I'm saying, "Okay A.B., either you can't hear or they can't hear." You know? So that's what gave me some confidence to write about it since it was being written about, the new music certainly being written about from a wrong-minded perspective and people were not open to it and could not hear what I heard. And I knew I had to trust my own experience most of all.

MR: That's interesting because there was a similar thing happening when bebop and the "moldy figs" they called them that couldn't absorb what was coming out of the instruments at that time.

AS: A lot of these critics who were putting the new jazz of the 60s down had been the defenders of bebop. It's an interesting thing, Pound, Ezra Pound who I don't like to quote but sometimes do, once said that it was referred to a cycle. He said there's a period when everything is set, all the rules are clear and there's no dissention on it, and the art in those periods is sterile. And then there's a revolution in the form and you get a lot of new artists, a lot of new artists who are taking an entirely different approach to the art, and they break through and that period is great of discovery, and a lot of great masterpieces are made then. And then that group ossifies into an academy and the same cycle repeats. All of the art — everything gets to be very conventional again based on the last revolution but you know the great exploration, the great breakthroughs are not occurring anymore. And then a new group of rebels appears you know. So I think that's true. I think that is true. It certainly was true in jazz.

MR: Years ago I went, it might have been the same jazz educators' gathering that you were at. There was a panel about, that was entitled "Trad Jazz Is Alive and Well" and it had some record label people and some players. But on the program for the three or four days there was no trad jazz groups that performed. I started thinking about jazz in the larger sense has been elevated to a high art form and it's in the universities and it is studied and you can get Ph.D.s in it but is New Orleans music and trad jazz and those twenty or thirty years, do you feel that that is respected as much as the music from John Coltrane and forward?

AS: I don't think a lot of people listen to New Orleans music anymore. It's too bad because it's still great music. There was a lot of brilliance in the 1920s and coming forward. And it still speaks, at least to me today. Louis Armstrong for example, was a voice for the

ages. I mean I don't think he will ever be obsolete. But still I think most people know Louis from the singing he did say during the 1950s to the end of his life than they do from the times when he was breaking through and establishing himself as the future of music. And there was one — Charles — what is his name — one of the great white Civil Rights lawyers had written about how he grew up in Texas in a world of segregation and had assumed all of the things that go with segregation and Jim Crow about inferiority/superiority, and then you heard Louis Armstrong play and you said this man is a genius. And he had to face the fact that if he's a genius then all these other stuff can't be true. So it's amazing how music can change so much in a person. But at any rate I think that the great music is still alive but a capacity to hear certain great music isn't always there. I mean I think that you know I think that people who listen to classical music, a lot of them really can't abide things like motets or early masses, and that's still great music. So yes, I think for me the masterpieces remain masterpieces and you can listen to them at any time.

MR: I had the good fortune to interview the trombone player Benny Powell. And he said in his opinion no great art ever came from happiness — that there had to be adversity for, he said "great art to be formed." And I wonder how you feel about that?

AS: I don't think that's true. That's one of the myths about art is that you've got to be miserable and alienated. That isn't true at all. I've been happy most of my life, not to name myself a great artist but I don't find that I made better work when I was depressed and miserable than I did when I was happy. I don't think that's true of other artists as well. I feel like Cecil Taylor, he wasn't a miserable person. He was basically in a good mood every time I saw him, most times that I saw him at any rate. Coltrane was a quiet guy but I don't look on his as being a sad and miserable person. So no, I think that you know that's one of the myths that goes along with things like the blues you know what I mean? But even the blues is not a miserable form. I mean most blues songs are quite up, quite joyful.

MR: Yes. Count Basie for sure.

AS: Definitely.

MR: Yeah. With your poetry at what point do the titles of your poems occur?

AS: Generally after the fact. And sometimes well after the fact. I view titles as like caps you know? They don't have to look like the rest of the suit but they do have to be in harmony with it.

MR: I see. That's a terrific analogy. So you're obviously familiar with the tune "Groovin' High" and you wrote a poem called "Groovin' Low."

AS: Oh yeah.

MR: And would you consent to read that for me?

AS: Certainly. Well whatever "Groovin' High" is about, and I will make no assumptions, "Groovin' Low" is about getting older. And I do want to say for anybody who happens to be watching this video that the weird words in the second stanza are terms of the drum. I didn't make these words up.

"Groovin' Low"

my swing is more mellow
these days: not the hardbop drive
i used to roll but more of a cool
foxtrot. my eyes still close
when the rhythm locks; i've learned
to boogie with my feet on the floor
i'm still movin', still groovin'
still fallin' in love

i bop to the bass line now
the trap set paradiddles ratamacues and flams
that use to spin me in place still set me
off but i bop to the bass line now
i enter the tune from the bottom up
& let trumpet & sax wheel above me

so don't look for me in the treble
don't look for me in the fly
staccato splatter of the hot young horn
no you'll find me in the nuance
hanging out in inflection & slur
i'm the one executing the half bent
dip in the slow slow drag
with a smug little smile
& the really cool shades.

MR: That's marvelous. Thank you very much. I'm going to use a term you used to describe a Cannonball Adderley solo. It was perfect, not a wrong note.

AS: Thank you. Yeah, well, I revise a lot. I try to be sure that every word is the right word. A lot of people don't like revision. I think that for poetry I don't think that there are — I've

only known maybe two people in my life who could write a poem without revision and it would be worthy of publication. And I even thought that those poems would have improved if they had sat down and gone over and changed a thing here and there.

MR: When you're considering revisions do you read it aloud?

AS: No but I hear it.

MR: You hear it. Okay.

AS: I hear it, yeah, I definitely hear it. And I use a lot of iambics not because — it's not an intentional matter I don't have any particular brief for iambics except that the lines have to scan for me. They have to scan. And they have to swing a little bit. And I think iambics help me do that.

MR: There are decisions you and other poets make regarding uppercase letters. And I'm looking at the poem and there's no uppercase. And I've wondered in the past, what is the — is there a reason for that?

AS: I used to have one and it had to involve the diminution of the ego and of the — having more poetry of equality where everything stood at the same level. I got used to me having that it's nice, but the fact is I just do it because I've always done it. And I try to punctuate with measure. I very seldom — I punctuate when I can't get out of it. Question marks for example, I can't find a way around, but usually I try to punctuate at the end of the line on the page would be where the period would be. And I sometimes like to have, I like to have words bump into each other without commas or semicolons or the like interrupting them. I think you can find more things in the relationship with the words I think without punctuation being there. Not everybody agrees with that approach. But it's fairly common nowadays. I used to be, you know, sort of out there by doing it but now I see it all the time.

MR: I see. Well thank you for sharing that with me. I wanted to go back to this, I heard you and Murray Horwitz on the air, a re-play of one of the albums you picked for that marvelous jazz review and it was Cannonball and "Something Else." And on the "Autumn Leaves" you called his solo "perfect, not a wrong note." And I'm a huge Cannonball fan so it really caught my attention. And it's been a while but can you recall why you felt it was perfect?

AS: Why I felt it was perfect. Well Cannonball had a gift for connecting his notes in such a way that every one seemed like the right note. Now some other people like, again, Coletrane again would be more like challenging with the way his notes related to each other. He would create all these tensions within his music and even use things like quarter tones to challenge your ear a bit more. So the sense of rightness that this is the correct note doesn't come into it in the same way that it would with Cannonball. With Coltrane the next note was more of an adventure. With Cannonball it was more of a validation of

everything that had gone before it. And so that was a great gift of Cannonball's. He did this time after time after time, I mean that everything seemed to flow very very logically out of everything else. And it made his solos appear like organic, like little bodies of things. And also he had just such a beautiful sound, just a perfect, perfect casual way of phrasing, playing very difficult passages as if they were just the easiest things in the world to express. I had a great admiration for his music.

MR: Did you know him personally?

AS: Never met Cannonball. No, never met him.

MR: I met Nat.

AS: I did meet him once in Atlanta. I did meet him.

MR: What is your opinion — this strays off a little bit. When historians look back on our current time in the United States do you have any idea what they will say about it?

AS: About this time?

MR: Yes. About this time and this —

AS: I think they will say that this is a time when fascism took serious hold in the United States. I think that there is a protofascism growing on the right which is absolutely terrifying and it is stronger than anything on the left at this particular moment. And the question is how will all this resolve. I think that there's such a move, I think Donald Trump introduced such an attitude of authoritarianism and a disregard for institutions or for the laws and rules that had held society together for a while, even with all the contradictions that American society has had within it, and that disregard has taken root in a portion of the country now that makes it all very frightening to me. I think we're in some serious trouble.

MR: I can't disagree. I wonder if you have any thoughts about how we get out of it.

AS: Well some of it I don't have thoughts because a lot of it has to do with the Internet and that I never understood, this electronic age, in a way that gives me a critique of it that would make any sense to anybody. So that part of it no. I think that there has to be more of a unity among people who would oppose this rise of fascism and at least unity on certain principles that this has to be stopped, even if they can't find unity on where society goes afterwards. But I think now the focus is it should be to stop the rise of this authoritarian right.

MR: Okay. Thanks for addressing that. Back to the music for a moment —

AS: Please.

MR: Where does blues fit in the art forms that we are so, they are so much a part of American culture. As I said before, you can now get a Ph.D. in jazz studies but there are no such levels of academia that focus on the blues. Do you know if there's a reason for that?

AS: Well the fact that I think that jazz musicians have been more aggressive and challenging the institutions, to incorporate them. And blues musicians have not had that kind of orientation. They have not based them in academic people and whereas jazz musicians in the latter part of the twentieth century were more academically inclined. And once you started getting like, and communities demanded it too. Like for example the demand for black studies in the 1960s would lead to the establishment of jazz programs because that's something that a university could do to address its omission of African-American cultural development, including African-American history within its curricula. And also there was more of a faculty to be had. So yes I mean I think — I very much remember the way it was when I first went to the National Endowment for the Arts in 1977. At that time jazz was considered to be commercial music, completely unworthy of being addressed by cultural institutions including universities. It belonged outside of it. It's a large part of jazz's history as you know, which has always been outside of history up until again this current age. So once you started getting jazz programs established some of the early programs like the one at North Texas State, which developed a really good jazz orchestra, didn't have many black people in it but it did at least recognize the music and showed that you could have a serious academic curriculum that could develop the music. Once that momentum started then of course it spread to where every conservatory had to have some kind of a jazz program. Now it hasn't been altogether a great thing, because again, something gets lost when you make these big social based transformations in the music. We now have more — this generation of jazz musicians, which has more technique, knows more theory and more history than any other, and yet it's you almost can't tell them apart, the products of these things. Something gets lost when you have to make these discoveries of the instrument on your own without being told how to play it by a professor. Maybe an older musician on the instrument will give you some tips every now and then but basically you had to find it yourself. But in so doing you do develop a voice and you develop a sound. So the generations of musicians where you hear a phrase of Ben Webster and know it's Ben Webster, you know what I mean, that is gone. Also I find it odd that with all these musicians, again more technically adept, more theoretically sound than any other generation, we haven't had an overriding genius appear since John Coltrane. And he died in 1967. That's 55 years ago. Coltrane and Charlie Parker overlapped. You know? Louis Armstrong and Charlie Parker overlapped. You know? Art Tatum overlapped with bebop musicians. But, so it's in a strange place. I don't really understand where it goes or how it goes but maybe —

MR: How do you define genius? I remember talking to Phil Woods who very honestly made the assessment of himself, that he was a craftsman not an innovator. And I wonder if,

well to get back to my original question, do you have a definition for yourself of a genius in any field?

AS: Well it's my definition, it won't conform with the dictionary's definition, but a genius to me is a person who makes his or her medium different from the way it was before them. You see? And I think a lot of the genius may have gone out of jazz when it became more bourgeois. I mean that ghetto genius that produced Charlie Parker, you know, and Bud Powell and Thelonious Monk now got lost to hip hop because we took the instruments away from the kids. So they made a music out of words. If that genius had gone into jazz we would have a different jazz you see. But I don't know what to do about it, I mean I'm definitely I'm for all kinds of training programs in communities of people who are without resources. I'm for all of that. But I don't know how we get that back.

MR: This is, I'm not sure we can get into this subject at this point, I'll just throw it out that white musicians often times seem to have more success with a certain style that was created by African-American musicians. Do you think Cecil Taylor was observing the success of people like Dave Brubeck and feeling the unfairness of it?

AS: Yes, he talked about things like that. He did feel that way, that it was very unfair. I mean he didn't blame Brubeck for it, but he felt like the society will accept, at least a society of people with resources — basically white people — will accept white musicians playing the music over black musicians. And we can see that in popular music very very easily. You know Elvis, whom I did not consider to be a very talented person. I mean I didn't like the way he sang, I thought he was a very awkward dancer, but nevertheless there was Elvis. You know what I mean? And how many black musicians were more talented than Elvis. Jerry Lee Lewis I had some respect for, if I was to pick a Memphis white boy I'll take him, but it is that sense. The Beatles, Beatles covers, the early Beatles covers of soul music recordings, you know and the Rolling Stones, "Time is on my Side" You know, a much better song on Wilson Pickett. A much bigger song when it's sung from Britain.

MR: I see. Well I have enjoyed this conversation so much, and I'll do something that interviewers really aren't supposed to do but I'll do it anyway. Is there anything that you'd like to talk about that I haven't asked you?

AS: Let me think. No, I'm pretty much talked out. I'm getting a little hoarse in the throat now.

MR: Okay.

AS: Can't talk as long as I used to.

MR: Yeah. Well I'm going to paraphrase something you wrote in your introduction to your *Four Lives in Bebop* and I'm paraphrasing for this occasion, and I'll say, "I hope I have not put any words in your mouth, you have enough marvelous words of your own."

AS: Thank you a lot, Monk, I enjoyed this talking to you.

MR: I appreciate it Mr. Spellman, and I'll sign off our recording and then we'll just say goodbye.

AS: You'll send me a copy of this, right?

MR: I will indeed.

AS: Okay. Thank you.